Master Class

By Terrence McNally

NOTE: *This selection requires the actress to sing lines from Verdi's Macbeth in Italian. At the end of this selection, you will find a link to the actual aria as sung by Maria Callas, as well as the translation of the aria. Consultation with an opera instructor is recommended.*

MARIA: *(Grand entrance, with bows to unheard applause, she "quiets" the phantom crowd)* No applause. We're here to work. You're not in a theatre. This is a classroom. This is a master class. Singing is serious business. We're going to roll up our sleeves and work. I appreciate your welcome but enough is enough.

INTRODUCTION

Maria Callas was a Greek-American soprano, and one of the most renowned and influential opera singers of the 20th century. Callas's most distinguishing quality was her ability to breathe life into the wide range of characters she portrayed. Critic Conrad Osborne says it also contained the seeds of her vocal decline. Callas lacked the formal training in proper technique to sustain her ambitious repertoire; and her voice was already starting to fail her by the time she was in her 40s — quite young for an opera singer.

In Master Class by Terrence McNally we join Maria Callas at the end of her career. After losing the strength of her voice, she decides to use her knowledge of opera to teach at Julliard. This is a snapshot of her teaching technique and a brief glimpse into the heart of who Maria Callas really was: Master Class by Terrence McNally

MARIA: *(looking at index cards she has been carrying)* Who's next? Lady Macbeth, Tosca, Lucia. I must say, what these students lack in voice and technique, they make up for in self-confidence. Don't laugh. That's important. Well, we shall see what we shall see. Next victim! That was a joke. My last one, I promise. *(To 2nd Soprano)* ***Avanti, Avanti!*** Don't linger. If you're going to enter, enter. If you don't want to be out here, go away. Now who have we here?

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2nd SOPRANO: Sharon Graham

MARIA: So Sharon Graham. What are you going to sing for us?

2nd SOPRANO: Lady Macbeth?

MARIA: The Sleepwalking Scene, I suppose.

2nd SOPRANO: No, ***"Vieni! T'affretta,"*** I thought.

MARIA: Ah, the Letter Scene! Well, that's something. They usually all want to start with the Sleepwalking Scene. You're humble, like me, that's good. So. This is her entrance aria, yes?

2nd SOPRANO: Yes.

MARIA: So what are you going out here? Go away. We don't want to see you yet.

2nd SOPRANO: You want me to go off and come back out?

MARIA: No, I want you to enter. You're on a stage. Use it. Own it. This is opera, not a voice recital. Anyone can stand there and sing. . An artist enters and ***is***.

2nd SOPRANO: It thought you said this was a classroom.

MARIA: *(withering look)* Astonish us, Sharon.

2nd SOPRANO: How do I do that?

MARIA: You can start by not entering as Sharon Graham. Enter as Lady Macbeth. Enter as Shakespeare's Lady Macbeth.

2nd SOPRANO: I'll do my best.

MARIA: And Sharon, may I say one more thing? That's a beautiful gown, obviously. We've all been admiring it.

2nd SOPRANO: Thank you.

MARIA: But don't ever wear anything like that before midnight at the earliest and certainly not to class. We're talking about what's appropriate. This is a matter class, not some Cinderella's ball. Eh? Off you go now. And come back as her. Come back as Lady. *(2nd SOPRANO exits.)* Sometimes we just have to say these things, eh? I auditioned for Edward Johnson at the old Met wearing a

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red and white polka-dot dress, white gloves, a blue hat with a veil and what I later learned were known as "Catch me / your "F"-word-me" pumps. I'm sorry, but that's what they were called. I was overweight and looked like and American flag singing Madame Butterfly. She'll thank me one day. Are we ready? Begin. *(Accompanist begins to play. Maria listens hard, making sounds along with it, rather than actually singing the notes).* The curtain is flying up now. No Sharon yet. This is an interesting choice for an entrance. I was onstage at this point. *(The music stops. No sign of the 2nd SOPRANO)* Sharon? We're all waiting. Excuse me. *(She leaves the stage and comes back a moment later)* No Sharon. She's gone. If her skin is that thin, she's not suited for this career. It's not like I said anything about her voice. I didn't even let her open her mouth. Next student! *(2nd Soprano comes back onto the stage)*

2nd SOPRANO: I'm back! *(Maria looks at her blankly)* I'd like to try again. I've been in the ladies room throwing up. I must have . . . *(Maria holds up her hand to stop 2nd Soprano from going into further detail)* So should I go out and come in again? *(Maria nods)* I'll yell when I'm ready! *(2nd Soprano exits) (Off)* I'm ready! (accompanist begins entrance music again – 2nd Soprano enters at the *appropriate moment. The music stops and she begins to sing)*

"Nel di della vittoria io le incontrai.
Stupito io n'era per le udite cose;"

MARIA: Where's your letter? You're meant to be reading a letter.

2nd SOPRANO: I was pretending to hold one. Couldn't you tell?

MARIA: I don't want pretending. You're not good enough. I want truth. This is a letter. *(She seizes a piece of paper and thrusts it at Sharon.)* What are you saying?

2nd SOPARNO: I'm saying "I met them on the day of victory. I was rapt in wonder at the things I heard. When the King's messengers hailed me as Thane of Cawdor"

MARIA: Put some wonder in your voice! Thane of Cawdor! It's what she's dreamed of.

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2nd SOPRANO: Thane of Cawdor! "A prediction made by those same seers who foretold a crown upon my head. Keep deep in your heart these secrets. ***Addio.***"

MARIA: Do you know this speech in Shakespeare?

2nd SOPRANO: I've read the play, of course, but that was in high school.

MARIA: You want to sing this music without knowing your Shakespeare!

2nd SOPRANO: I'm not an actress. I'm just a singer.

MARIA: Do you think Verdi composed it without knowing his Shakespeare? ***Vergogna***, Sharon, shame. And that wasn't an entrance. You came on but it wasn't an entrance. An entrance is everything. It's how we present ourselves to an audience. It's how we present ourselves in life. I'll show you an entrance. You can set the scene for our colleagues. Just read from the score. *(She quickly leaves the stage. The 2nd Soprano picks up and reads from Maria's score. The accompanist begins again.)*

2nd SOPRANO: "Scene Two. The grand hall in Macbeth's castle. There are several rooms leading off it. There is a grand staircase descending from the floor above. There are two small thrones. It is night. A violent storm is raging. Thunder. Lightning. Rain. Curtain. Lady Macbeth enters at the top of the stairs. She is magnificently arraigned. She is reading a letter. *(Maria has entered as Verdi's Lady Macbeth, reading a letter.)*

MARIA: ***"Nel di della vittoria io le incontrai.***
Stupito io n'era per le udite cose;"

(Maria begins to sing the first lines of Lady Macbeth's recitative. What comes out is a cracked and broken thing. A voice in ruins. It is a terrible moment.)

(Angrily) Go on, you're the student here. Not I. And see how important a prop is?

2nd SOPRANO: You hardly looked at the letter.

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MARIA: *(condescendingly)* She has it memorized. She's read it over and over and over. My choice. Not Verdi's. Not Shakespeare's. Callas. You think you can do that now?

2nd SOPRANO: Not like you.

MARIA: I don't want it done like me. I want it done like Verdi. With music. This isn't a play.

2nd SOPRANO: **"Ambizioso spirit tu sei Macbetto."**

MARIA: There's two "t's" in Macbetto. I want to hear them.

2nd SOPRANO: Mac –

MARIA: Don't repeat, keep going!

2nd SOPRANO: **"Alla grandezza aneli, ma sari tu malvagio?"**

MARIA: "You would be great, but will you be wicked?" Ah, there's the question! Don't even think of stopping! You are Lady Macbeth! *(Maria circles the 2nd Soprano, working with her)* Use this introduction to focus yourself. Why are you moving your hand? Never move your hand unless you follow it with your heart and soul.

2nd SOPRANO: How do I know when to move at all?

MARIA: The composer tells you. It's all in the music. Now!

2nd SOPRANO: **"Vieni! T-affretta! Accendere"**

MARIA: Bite into those words. Spit them out.

2nd SOPRANO: **"Ti vo' quell freddo core!"**

MARIA: Let yourself go. Who are you saving it for? The melody broadens here. Let it through you.

2nd SOPRANO: **"Le profetesse il trono."**

MARIA: The throne of Scotland has been promised to him! What is he waiting for? This is important to you! You make we want to shake you, Sharon!

2nd SOPRANO: **Ascendivi a regnar. Che tardi?"**

MARIA: What are you waiting for? Acccept the gift. Take what I'm giving you.

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2nd SOPRANO: Che tardi? Accetta il dono,

Ascendi, ascendi, ascendivi a regnar."

MARIA: Rise and rule. Rise and take your place in this world. This isn't just an opera. This is your life. Am I right? So what happens here? Hurry up, you're running out of steam.

2nd SOPRANO: Someone comes in an

MARIA: Not someone. Noone is someone.

2nd SOPRANO: A servant.

MARIA: Now you're talking!

2nd SOPRANO: He tells her that the king, Duncan! Will be at their castle that very evening.

MARIA: Is Macbeth with him?

2nd SOPARANO: Yes!

MARIA: And how does that make her feel?

2nd SOPRANO: Happy?

MARIA: Don't keep looking at me for answers, Sharon. Tell me, show me. ***Vite, vite!*** What is she going to do about it?

2nd SOPRANO: She's going to sing a cabaletta!

MARIA: She's going to kill the King! Do you know what that means?

2nd SOPRANO: Yes, it's terrible.

MARIA: Not to her! Do you believe women can have balls, Sharon?

2nd SOPRANO: Some women. Yes, I do!

MARIA: Verdi is daring you to show us yours, Sharon. Will you do it?

2nd SOPRANO: Yes!

MARIA: Tonight! It's now or never. She's going crazy here. It's all in the music. Listen to those dissonances. Don't act, listen. It's always in the music, Sharon. Don't look at me for help. Listen to Verdi, listen to Shakespeare.

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2nd SOPRANO: ***Or tutti sorgete, ministry infernali***
Che al sangue incorate –
Spingeti I mortali! Che al sangue incoret mortali!
Tu note ne avvolgi –
Di tenebra immota"

MARIA: Is there anything you would kill for, Sharon? A man, a career?

2nd SOPRANO: Not off the top of my head.

MARIA: You have to listen to something in yourself to sing this difficult music. These people really existed. Lady Macbeth. Or don't you believe that? Eh? This is all make-believe to you?

2nd SOPARANO: I've never really through about it.

MARIA: That's because you're young. You will. In time. Know how much suffering there can be in store for a woman.

2nd SOPRANO: But you were young when you first sang Lady Macbeth.

MARIA: I was never young. I couldn't afford to be. Not to get to where I was going. Anyway. Enough of that. You came back. You had ***mut***. That's something. Do you know that German word? It means courage. I had to know it when I sand Fidelio for the Germans during the Occupation during the way. It was at the Theatre Herod Atticus in Athens. I was 18 years old. I needed lots of ***mut*** that day. ***Mut.***

2nd SOPRANO: DO you want me to do it again?

MARIA: Yes! Off you go now *(2nd Soprano exits)* And this is for all of you: there are no short cuts in art, no easy ways. This isn't life, where there are so many. There is no being at center stage as if by magic. There is always an entrance first, just as there is always an exit after. Art is about those transitions. There is only discipline, technique and ***mut***. Are you ready back there? What is her name? Are you ready back there, Sharon?

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2nd SOPRANO: I think so.

MARIA: Don't think, don't hope, do. Mut, Sharon, mut. Every eye is on you.

2nd SOPRANO: ***"Nel di della vittoria io le incontrai.***

Stupito io n'era per le udite cose;"

MARIA: *(steps out of scene)* Let me be her. That sound of the curting parting. The stage dust. Don't breathe it in. They see me. "Who is this fat Greek girl we never heard of making her debut?" Ah! The silence. It's time. Begin.

"Nel di della vittoria io le incontrai.

Stupito io n'era per le udite cose;"

MARIA: That's who I am! This voice. Ah, Verdi! Ah, Shakespeare! Ah, my own ambition. IN less than one year I've become the Queen of La Scala. That has to count for something. La Divina. Imagine being called La Divina. I am La Divina. Listen to that! I've won. I've made something of myself.

2nd SOPRANO: *(breaking into her thoughts)* Mme. Callas?

MARIA: Sshh! Listen, they're applauding. Never move on your applause. It shortens it.

2nd SOPRANO: No one was applauding. You told them not to.

MARIA: *(sadly, broken)* I would never tell anyone that, ***ma chere***. The worst part about being a teacher is being misunderstood. Applause is what we live on. Sometimes it's the only thing we have. . . . *(hardening her outer shell again)* I think you have a lovely voice. [But] it takes more than a pretty voice to build a career.

2nd SOPRANO: I wish I'd never done this. I don't like you. You can't sing anymore and you're envious of anyone younger who can. You just want us to sing like you, recklessly, and lose our voices in 20 years like you do. Well, I won't do it. I don't want to. I don't want to sing like you. I hate people like you. You want to make the world dangerous for everyone just because it was for you. *(She leaves – awkward silence)*

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MARIA: So. I think we should stop here. Miss Graham thought I wanted her to sing like Maria Callas. No one can sing like Maria Callas. I am very upset. I'm hurt. As strange as it may seem to some of you, I have feeling too. Maybe this whole business of teaching is a mistake. Do not think singing is an easy career. It is a lifetime's work; it does not stop here. Whether I continue singing or not doesn't matter. What matters is that you use whatever you have learned wisely. Think of the expression of the words, of good diction, and of your own deep feelings. The only thanks I ask is that you sing properly and honestly. If you do this, I will feel repaid. *(She gathers her things and exits. Blackout)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2004 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2013 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

Inspiration for the sung lines can be found here:

Listen to the full aria "Vieni! T'affretta" by Maria Callas:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1XWcRrDTtJ8

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Translation into English by Ugo Berardi

Vieni! t'affretta!, Lady Macbeth's aria from Macbeth

Ambizioso spirto tu sei, Macbetto	Macbeth, you are an ambitious man.
Alla grandezza aneli ma sarai tu malvagio?	You want to be great, but will you be wicked?
Pien di misfatti è il calle dell potenza,	the way to the power is full of crimes,
E mal per lui	and plague on him
che il piede dubitoso vi pone, e retrocede!	that begins that way doubting and then goes back.
Vieni! t'affretta!	Come on! Hurry up!
Accendere ti vo' quel freddo core!	I will fire your cold heart!
L'audace impresa a compiere	I will make you able
Io ti darò valore.	to complete the bold undertaking.
Di Scozia a te promettono	The witches promise you
Le profetesse il trono...	the scottish throne...
Che tardi?	What are you waiting for?
Accetta il dono, ascendivi a regnar.	Accept this gift! Ascend it and reign!

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